

PART 6D/6E/6F: FACTION REPORTS OF THE GRAND GAME

[by Justin Alexander – March 21st, 2019](#)

Suspicion: Neverember's Enigma is nothing less than the 500,000 dragons embezzled from the city funds of Waterdeep.

These lengthy reports, which can be discovered within the various faction lairs, are designed to be given to the players as handouts. They provide the PCs an opportunity to peer deeper into the machinations of the Grand Game, and can also serve as a reference for the GM to figure out what knowledge each faction currently has (and which its agents might surrender under questioning).

The reports here do not necessarily reflect the knowledge held by each faction at the very beginning of [Dragon Heist](#). They have been written to reflect the state of the reports at the time the PCs are most likely to encounter them (during the Eye Heists). During earlier events, the factions may still be trying to piece together some of this information. (Most notably, if the PCs stage a heist at the Sea Maidens Faire without tipping off Jarlaxle about the Grand Game, there won't be any report as he will not yet be involved in the Grand Game.) As the events of the campaign develop, you may also want to update these reports to reflect ongoing events (including explicit or implicit references to the activities of the PCs).

You'll note that each faction refers to the Eyes using a different nomenclature. This complicates things slightly for the players (who need to figure out which names equate to which names), but not significantly. The real point of this is to deepen verisimilitude: These factions don't all compare notes. Each faction has a unique perspective on the Grand Game, and allowing the players to see that in practical ways will make it clear that the game world is a dynamic, interactive place, not a monolithic entity.

As a quick reference, when the PCs get drawn into the Grand Game:

- The *Stone of Golorr* was stolen by Xanathar. It was taken from Xanathar by Dalakhar, and taken from Dalakhar by the Gralhunds.
- Xanathar's Eye was originally stolen by the Zhentarim from the Protector's Enclave in Neverwinter. Xanathar slew a Zhentarim embassy and took the Eye.
- The Zhentarim Eye was taken from Renaer's mourning locket.
- The Cassalanter Eye was taken from the crypt of Lady Alethea Brandath.

The reports are presented in both plain text and also as PDFs with fancy handwriting fonts.

GRALHUND STUDY OF THE GRAND GAME

These disparate papers, written in the hand of Orond Gralhund, concern the strategies and machinations of House Gralhund.

Uktar 4th, 1491 DR

They have treated us like fools. In the wake of the Lord Murders, with so many vacancies among the Lords and with Yalah's lineage, it should have required no effort at all for her to be elevated to her rightful place. For the Gralhunds to be elevated to their rightful place, so that she could guarantee the prosperity of the Gralhunds for future generations. Instead they have taken our money. They have taken our favor. And they have spat in our faces. They have closed their ranks against us once again.

This journal entry, and others like it throughout late 1491 DR, speak to the bitterness of the Gralhunds, who felt slighted by being excluded from the ruling council of the city.

Nightlet 21st, 1491 DR

At the fires of Simril last night, Lord Berenger spoke to me of a curious matter. Neverember's Enigma. It seems that the former Open Lord kept some monstrous secret, and now word of that secret is beginning to spread. There are those who believe a Grand Game may be beginning. I sense in this an opportunity to right the great wrong which has been done to Yalah.

It is clear from Orond's notes, however, that over the next few weeks his efforts to penetrate the Grand Game were stymied. The resources of the Gralhunds were limited. But Orond thought outside the box: He embedded agents (referred to by the codephrases "Eagle" and "Catoblepas") in Renaer Neverember's household. As Renaer was estranged from his father this was a long-shot at best, but it paid off. A report from Eagle reads:

*We've identified the gnome who's been keeping surveillance on R.N. Dalakhar.
An agent of Lord D. Please advise.*

Several weeks later, the gnome Dalakhar abruptly stopped his surveillance of Renaer Neverember. Eagle played a hunch, followed up, and discovered that Dalakhar had ended up in the employ of the Xanathar Guild.

Dal. must still be acting under the orders of Lord D. No other explanation for the sudden shift of allegiance.

Contemporary notes from other sources allowed Orond to begin piecing certain facts about the Grand Game and Neverember's Enigma.

*There are Three Eyes with which Neverember's Enigma may be seen.
The First Eye is held by Xanathar, and lies somewhere within his lair.
Bulette's report that this lair can be accessed from teleportal sites within
X's sewer hideouts provides a potential means by which this Eye could
seized, but in the absence of a synchronized key these teleportal sites are
useless.*

A later note states:

*The Second Eye has almost certainly been taken from R/V by the
Cherlarim. It is more important than ever that we discover where M has
hidden his head.*

And then, this:

*Xanatharians are riled. Word on the street is that something was stolen from
them. But not the First Eye. The stone of Golarr.*

This report is attached to analysis written by Orond.

*What if the "Key to Neverember's Enigma" which Xanathar was
known to hold in his possession is not, as I have suspected, the Eye?
But instead the Stone of Golarr? If so, then what better thief than an
agent of Dagutt's? Perhaps even sent there for that purpose. The gnome
has taken the Stone, I am certain of it. If we can find Dalakhar, then we
can seize the Key. We can take the Stone.*

JARLAXLE'S REPORT ON THE GRAND GAME

(written in silver ink upon black paper)

This meticulously organized folder of intelligence reports and summaries appears to have been compiled by "Jarlaxle Baenre." It is clear from its contents that Jarlaxle was, until recently, unaware of the Grand Game currently taking place in Waterdeep. Once he got an inkling of what was happening, however, he evidently took immediate steps to remedy the situation. In these efforts, the "Gralhund nimblewright has proven most useful," but the information obtained by the Gralhunds is apparently "woefully incomplete." Despite that, Jarlaxle was apparently able to draw a significant conclusion.

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Once that conclusion was reached, Jarlaxle's interest in the matter clearly spiked and he intensified efforts to bring himself up to speed, dispatching Bregan D'Aerthe, a covert band of mercenary agents in his command, to gather as much information as they could by any means necessary.

It seems that Jarlaxle's interest is driven by a desire to win favor with Laeral Silverhand, the Open Lord of Waterdeep, by returning the stolen money to her.

There are numerous factions in play, but I suspect the most significant are these: The Cassalanthers, Xanathar (that bloated bag of gas), the Manshoonian Zhentarim, the Gralhunds, Lord Dagult, and the Open Lord. It seems that other players, like the Black Viper, are also involved, or interested in involving themselves, and some attention should be paid to how they might be turned to good use.

Of prime importance are the Golorr Eyes: Xanathar's Eye, I suspect, has been entrusted to Sylgar's keeping. Manshoon's Eye is almost certainly secured within Kolat Towers. The Cassalanter's Eye probably lies somewhere in their Estate.

Gaining control of an Eye must be our top priority. Those who control a Golorr Artifact are the pivots on which the outcome of the Grand Game will turn.

CASSALANTER FACTION REPORT ON THE GRAND GAME

Notes on Neverember's Enigma

By late 1487 DR, it had become clear to those with the right connections that the Open Lord had begun another of his secretive enterprises. A great deal of quiet attention was turned upon this matter, not the least of which was our own.

Of course, when there are many searching for answers, it is prudent to keep as careful an eye upon the other searchers as upon that for which you search. It was from the Roanishomus we learned that Neverember had sent agents to Candlekeep to make discreet inquiries regarding 'an archmage named Golann.' The Roanishomus mistook this intelligence, first believing that the Enigma ultimately concerned the dark elves by way of the Sincere, Archmage of Myerphennargau, and their expending great energy in pursuing rumors of Galani, an Archmage of Ancient Netheril.

Golann was the true name of interest, however. The Stone of Golann. According to some histories, it was brought to Abeir-Tonil when the ancient floating city of Xriphe, capital of the Abolethic Sovereignty, first plummeted to the world and settled deep below the Sea of Fallen Stars. According to others, an aboleth who came to Abeir-Tonil before the arrival of Xriphe created the Stone. Or perhaps he fled to Abeir-Tonil carrying the Stone and Xriphe came in pursuit of their prize. Some versions of the tale claim that the Stone was forged during the primal battles between Shan and Selune, in the very moment that the world of Tonil was formed.

Whatever the truth, the Stone of Golann was held by the Abolethic Sovereignty within the vaults of Xriphe in the world of Abeir, only to be lost during the Wailing Years.

Of far more interest is what the Stone is capable of. Whether it predates or co-dates the creation of Tonil, in arcane terms this gives

the Stone a position of primacy, making it capable of effects which no magic item or artifact created in these younger days could possibly duplicate.

When the proper ritual is performed, the Stone can utterly eradicate a memory or piece of information, wiping it clean from scrolls and inscriptions while simultaneously stripping it from every living soul on Toril except for the person who is attuned to the Stone. The Stone itself also retains the knowledge, making it the ultimate repository of countless ages of knowledge deemed valuable enough to hide from the world. Exactly what piece of knowledge Neverember sought to claim from the Stone pales utterly in comparison to the totality of secrets which its owner can literally hold in the palm of their hands.

The ritual required for the Stone to destroy a piece of knowledge requires a second abolethic artifact, a small tetrahedron of red jade. We now believe that this artifact remains in Lord Neverember's possession.

It was those gossipmongers the Brassfeathers who first babbled out the revelation that Neverember had embezzled half a million gold dragons from the treasures of Waterdeep. Half a million dragons which had seemingly vanished from the knowledge of man, woman, and fae.

It was then that we realized that, unlike ourselves, Neverember had not been captivated by the secrets held by the Stone. He wished to forge a new secret of his own. We are now certain that he used the Stone to hide the location in which he has secreted the embezzled dragons. As such, it is virtually certain that the only path to this hoard lies through the Stone itself.

Notes on the Mplainskyer Vault

In addition to the Stone of Golenn, our own researches indicated that Lord Neverember had been researching the religious mummery of the Mplainskyer dwarves.

Class Mplainskyer were the first to begin excavating under what is now Waterdeep. The earliest portions of Undermountain were, in fact, the Underhalls in which they made their homes and wrought their mithral-craft. They were worshippers of Dumathoin, the Keeper of the Mountain's Secrets.

When we learned of the Stone's relationship to the keeping of secrets, it seemed clear to us that Neverember's two esoteric pursuits must be linked. The nature of this link, however, eluded us until our attention turned to the ceremonial vaults which the Mplainskyer once built. Their cult believed that Dumathoin encoded his secrets into the veins of one and precious stones he placed in the mountains he raised from the earth for the dwarven people. In their mining, the dwarves supposedly released Dumathoin's secrets into the world. This angered Dumathoin and created a period of discord between the dwarves and the Mplainskyer, the council of dwarven gods. In order to appease their petty gods, the Mplainskyer would mystically bind the 'secrets of the mountain' into items of finely-wrought dwarfcraft and then make offerings of it to Dumathoin by securing them within their ceremonial vaults.

One of these vaults had been built near the Underhalls, most likely somewhere beneath what is now Waterdeep. We quickly discovered, however, that the knowledge of its location has been lost. Indeed, the more we delved into this matter, the clearer it became that there was a very specific pattern to the loss of this knowledge. Although a recherche topic, once we had found the proper sources from past ages it was fairly trivial to find any number of facts

regarding the Vault. The only piece of information that was systematically missing from every account was its location.

It is difficult to say for certain, but it seems overwhelmingly likely that this loss is consistent with a Golano-wipe. The knowledge lost in such a wipe is very specific, and if someone had sought to eliminate the knowledge of the Vault's location, it would nevertheless leave other lore regarding the Vault intact, in just such a fashion as we discovered it.

The first suspicion was that Neverember had been seeking the location of the Mplainskyr Vault and had similarly concluded that it was a secret which could now only be learned from the Stone.

When Neverember's true interest in the Stone became clear to us, however, we quickly concluded that it was Neverember himself who had used the Stone to hide the Vault's location. Furthermore, it is recorded that the Vault was looted during the dark elf invasion which ended the Mplainskyr civilization and its secrets, whatever they may have been, were scattered to the corners of the world. Whatever there may be of value within the Vault, therefore, must have been placed there by Neverember.

The doors of a Mplainskyr Vault were ceremonially sealed. Opening the doors required a single a dragonscale to be laid upon the bas relief of the sun and then struck while lit by sunlight. If the doors should shut upon us while we stood within the Vault, they can reputedly be opened from within by simply laying a hand upon them.

Notes on the Disposition of the Eyes

As one of numerous inquiries, we discovered a hiding place beneath the crypt of Lord Dagult's late wife. Although we initially believed the powerful magical item we discovered there to be Neverember's Enigma, its identity and purpose eluded us until we became aware of the Stone of Golann.

It is now clear that Lord Dagult had the Stone of Golann blinded by removing its Eyes, and that the artifact we recovered was Alethea's Eye. Although it seems certain that Dagult's intention was focused on increasing the difficulty of anyone uncovering his own secrets, one is nevertheless left with the impression of a small child defacing that which they cannot understand out of petty spite.

Nevertheless, the complexity of the game has multiplied and we seek now not one Golann Artifact, but several.

Dagult's Eye was kept close by the Lord Protector, who carried it with him to Neverwinter and most likely had it on his person when Isral depose him as Open Lord. Nevertheless, Dagult's Eye was stolen from him by the Zheentarii and held for a time within the Kdat Towers. We attempted to seize the eye from Maerskoo, but found our efforts repulsed by the energy field surrounding the Towers. Before we could obtain one of the pass-amulets which allow access, Dagult's Eye was lost when Maerskoo sent it as part of an embassy to Savathan. Savathan had Maerskoo's agents slain and took Dagult's Eye for himself.

Brevaer's Eye was held by Lord Dagult's son. This Eye appears to have been taken from Brevaer during his kidnapping, although it is currently unclear to us whether its ultimate disposition lies with the agents of Savathan or Maerskoo.

A BRIEFING FOR XANATHAR CONCERNING THE GRAND GAME

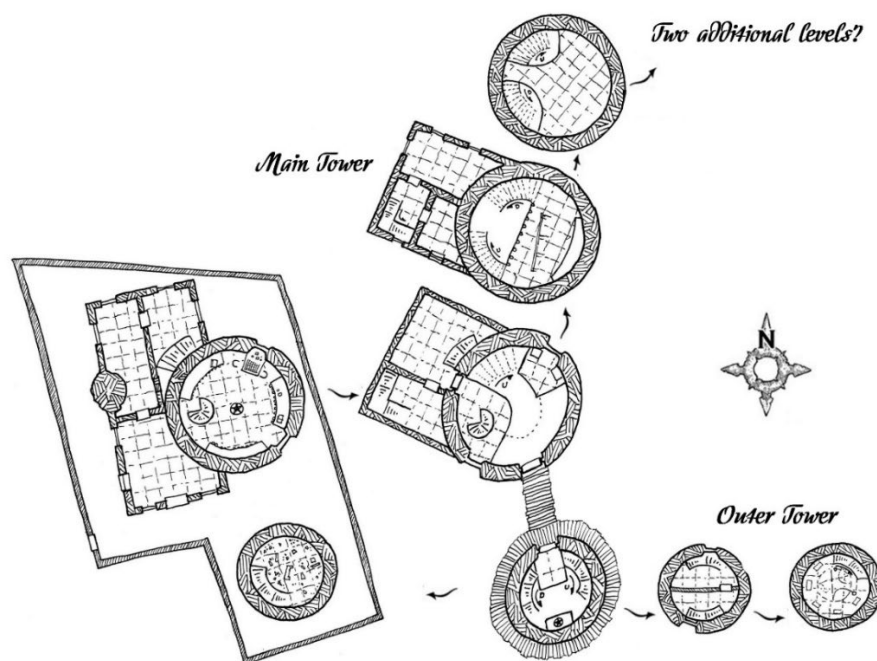
From the Hand of Ahingargo—

I am very sorry that we have failed you lord Xanathar. You should not have been surprised by the revelations of the emissaries of the ZhenAarin.

The litany of what we now know—

The Eye you hold is one of Three which belong to the Stone.

The Eye which should have been yours has been taken from Neverember's get by Manshoon to Kblat Towers. We currently seek to capture a ZhenAarin lieutenant and take possession of one of the pass-amulets which would allow us access to the Towers. Unfortunately, Manshoon's agents are well-trained and have either evaded our attempts or destroyed their amulets before we could secure them. Through N'ihiloor's enhanced interrogations, however, we have ascertained blueprints for the Towers which will prove essential when it comes time to take that which by right belongs to you.



We have also learned that Manshoon himself resides in an extradimensional citadel, accessible from a portal of some sort at the upper level of the Outer Tower.

The disposition of the Final Eye is uncertain to us at this time.

The gnome Dalakhar was an agent of Lord Neverember, seeking to reclaim Neverember's Enigma, which you had by rights taken from our former Open Lord.

The Enigma is, in fact, the Stone of Golorr. I have agents en route to Candlekeep to delve deeper into its secrets. The Stone once belonged to the Abolethic Sovereignty, and was reputedly stolen from the Vaults of the Floating City of Hæiphu by Mask, the Lord of Shadows. As a Hæiphuan Artifact, it is likely that the Stone predates the creation of Toril itself, granting it, within the circles of mysticism, a position of primacy. Its true powers, and thus the reason why Neverember sought to blind it, are unclear to us, but from a position of primacy it would be capable of feats impossible to duplicate even by Mystara herself in this Age.

MANSHOON'S REPORT ON THE GRAND GAME

Ritual of the Stone of Colors

The use of the Stone to magically eliminate a memory or piece of knowledge from the realms of Aheir-Toril requires a special casting of the legend lore rite which requires twelve hours to perform. In addition, one must possess a second Abolethic artifact, a small tetrahedron of red jade which I am certain is still held by Lord Dagult in Neverwinter.

During the ritual, burn incenses infused with the blood of an aboleth. The sides of the tetrahedron will unfold, revealing slots into which four ivory strips may be inserted. The Stone is then placed within the tetrahedron and the sides will close upon it.

As the ritual is completed, the tetrahedron will open once more, revealing the Stone of Colors as it releases a burst of psionic energy. This energy will refract through the person attuned to the Stone, translating the knowledge they focus upon and erasing it from the known world.

The Stone of Colors has been blinded by Lord Dagult.

The Neverwinter Eye was obtained from the Protector's Enclave in Neverwinter, but was taken by Xanathar's treachery. It remains in the beholder's possession.

The Waterdeep Eye has been taken from Renaer Neverember and secured within the library's Astral Vault.

It is apparent, based on interrogations of their impish agents, that the Cassalanterers possess the third eye, although it is uncertain where the Cassalanter Eye originated. Perhaps Lord Dagult entrusted it to them.²